Leadership Toolkit

Practical Situations

A4 | 10 FICTIONAL CASES | ENGLISH B2 | 2026

A concise working reference for SAP Leads: RACI, DACI, feedback, delegation, conflict resolution, delivery risk and spoken assessment practice.

STUDY SEQUENCE

- Choose a method only after identifying the actual problem.
- Understand RACI and DACI; use the sample assignment matrix.
- Read the ten situations and answer aloud before looking at the models.
- Handle pushback, then change one condition and answer again.
- Use the answer section to review business outcome, evidence, options, ownership and proof.

Print A4, portrait, double-sided, at actual size. The case prompts and model answers are separated to support active recall.

01 / METHOD CHOOSER

Start from the situation

A practical framework should make the next action clearer. The same technique will not solve every leadership problem.

Two teams think the other team owns the task. / RACI

One accountable owner and named people who do the work.

Everyone has an opinion but no one can close the decision. / DACI

One approver, options, criteria, and a decision date.

One person causes repeated problems in a meeting. / SBI / SBII

Specific feedback and one observable change.

The plan looks green but key assumptions are untested. / Pre-mortem and risk log

Failure scenarios, owners, mitigation, and a trigger.

A problem keeps returning to the Lead. / Delegation boundaries

A clear outcome, decision rights, and review points.

A 90-second answer in five moves

- State the business outcome and what is at risk.
- Separate confirmed facts from assumptions.
- Name the decision and its authorised owner.
- Compare options and explain important trade-offs.
- Close with the next action, owner, deadline and evidence.

02 / RESPONSIBILITY

RACI and DACI

RACI assigns responsibility for work. DACI clarifies how a specific decision is made. Do not use either as a substitute for clear approval authority.

R - Responsible

Does the work and produces the deliverable. One or more people can contribute, but the task must not become ownerless. Who will actually prepare, test, or fix it?

A - Accountable

Owns the outcome and accepts or signs off the work within their authority. Use one A for each row. Who is answerable if this deliverable is not ready?

C - Consulted

Gives input before work is completed or approved. This is a two-way conversation. Whose expertise or agreement must shape the work?

I - Informed

Receives relevant updates or the result, without another approval round. Who needs to know the outcome?

Which model fits?

What does it organise?

RACI: Tasks, handoffs and deliverable ownership. DACI: One choice that needs analysis and approval.

Who is key?

RACI: Responsible person and one Accountable owner per deliverable. DACI: Driver who moves the decision and Approver who closes it.

SAP example

RACI: Who prepares mapping, executes tests and signs off evidence? DACI: Should the order interface use an API, IDoc or event-based integration?

What does it not solve?

RACI: The technical design, conflicting objectives or the overall go/no-go authority. DACI: Who will do every delivery task after the decision.

03 / RACI IN PRACTICE

Testing and cutover ownership

Illustrative responsibilities for an end-to-end SAP SD testing process. Confirm the actual decision rights in your own programme.

Agree business acceptance criteria

A = Business owner | R = SD Lead | C = Integration Lead, Test Lead | I = Release Manager

Validate sales-order interface mapping

A = Integration Lead | R = Integration Lead | C = SD Lead, Test Lead | I = Business owner, Release Manager

Prepare end-to-end test data

A = Test Lead | R = SD Lead | C = Business owner, Integration Lead | I = Release Manager

Execute business UAT and log evidence

A = Business owner | R = Test Lead | C = SD Lead, Integration Lead | I = Release Manager

Assess business acceptance of open defects

A = Business owner | R = Test Lead | C = SD Lead, Integration Lead, Release Manager

Publish the cutover checklist

A = Release Manager | R = Release Manager | C = Business owner, SD Lead, Integration Lead, Test Lead

One accountable owner for each deliverable. People can be both accountable and responsible, but the approval boundary must be clear.

04 / LEADERSHIP METHODS

Tools that lead to action

01 / DECISIONS

Make ownership visible before debating options.

Many "technical disagreements" are really authority problems. We first define who drives the analysis, who decides, who contributes, and who only needs the outcome.

RACI

A delivery task falls between workstreams. | For each deliverable, agree who does the work, who owns the outcome, who is consulted, and who is informed. | Assign ownership of UAT data, interface checks, and cutover evidence.

DACI

A cross-team decision keeps circling. | Name one Driver and one Approver. Contributors advise; Informed receive the decision. | Choosing API, IDoc, or event for a new order integration.

Decision record

The choice will be challenged later. | Write context, options, decision, reasons, assumptions, risks, owner, and revisit trigger. | Why we accepted a temporary side-by-side extension before a clean-core replacement.

Reversible vs. hard-to-reverse

The team is over-analysing every choice. | Spend more evidence and senior attention on decisions that are expensive to undo. | A field label can move quickly; an enterprise BP numbering design cannot.

Pre-mortem

A plan looks suspiciously clean. | Assume the initiative failed. Ask what caused it. Convert the strongest causes into controls and owners. | Before cutover, imagine billing failed for the first business day and trace likely causes.

02 / CONFLICT

Do not fight positions. Find the interests behind them.

"We need custom code" and "we need clean core" are positions. The useful conversation is about speed, risk, upgrade cost, ownership, controls, and what must be true for each option to work.

Interests > options > criteria

Two stakeholders defend incompatible solutions. | Write what each side is protecting, create several options, then compare them against agreed criteria. | Trying to compromise before understanding the real constraints.

BATNA

A negotiation has a hard boundary. | Know what we will do if no agreement is reached. It prevents accepting a worse deal only to end tension. | Threatening with a weak or imaginary alternative.

Steelman first

The discussion has become tribal. | State the strongest version of the other side's argument before answering it. | Repeating a caricature and calling it alignment.

Escalate the decision, not the emotion

The team cannot close the issue at its authority level. | Escalate options, evidence, trade-offs, recommendation, and deadline. | Escalating people as "difficult" instead of escalating a blocked decision.

03 / FEEDBACK

Describe what happened. Do not diagnose the person.

Vague feedback creates defence. Specific feedback creates something we can work with.

SBI / SBII

Situation > observable Behaviour > Impact > ask about Intent. | "In today's design review, when the test concern was cut off twice, we lost the evidence we needed for approval. What were you trying to achieve in that moment?"

Feed-forward

After the fact is clear, define the next behaviour. | "For the next review, bring the risk and your proposed mitigation in the first five minutes."

Positive specificity

Reinforce behaviours worth repeating, not personality labels. | "You separated data, config, and interface hypotheses before testing. That shortened the diagnosis."

04 / DELEGATION

Delegate a result and a boundary.

If every decision returns to the Lead, we have distributed tasks but kept all ownership. That does not scale.

Investigate

Collect facts and options. | Lead decides.

Recommend

Analyse and propose a decision. | Lead approves or challenges.

Decide within guardrails

Own the decision inside defined cost, risk, architecture, or timeline limits. | Lead reviews exceptions, not every step.

Own outcome

Deliver the result and keep stakeholders aligned. | Lead checks evidence and system health.

05 / MOTIVATION

Motivation is usually a system problem before it is a speech problem.

We look at whether people can make meaningful choices, become better at the work, see why it matters, experience fair treatment, and notice progress.

Autonomy

Give a real decision boundary. | Every small choice needs permission.

Competence

Match challenge with support, review, and learning. | The same person receives only easy work or impossible work.

Purpose

Connect work to a business outcome. | The team only hears ticket numbers and deadlines.

Fairness

Make workload, recognition, and expectations explainable. | Invisible work always lands on the same people.

Progress

Make completed outcomes visible. | Long programmes feel like permanent incompletion.

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06 / PLANNING

Plan what we know, expose what we assume.

A date is not a plan. A useful plan shows deliverables, dependencies, capacity, uncertainty, risk, owners, and the next decisions.

Backward planning

Cutover, assessment, release, milestone. | Start from the proof of done and work backward through prerequisites.

Critical dependency map

Cross-team delivery. | Track the few dependencies that can block the outcome, with owners and needed-by dates.

Assumption log

Early estimates and architecture work. | If an estimate depends on something unproven, write it as an assumption with a validation date.

Risk = probability x impact, then action

Prioritising attention. | The score is not the work. Every material risk needs mitigation, contingency, owner, and trigger.

Buffer by uncertainty

Plans with discovery or external dependencies. | Do not hide uncertainty inside every task. Make contingency visible at the appropriate level.

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07 / REPORTING

Report for a decision, not for decoration.

Senior stakeholders rarely need all activity. They need to know whether the outcome is moving, what changed, what can hurt it, and where they must decide.

Outcome

What moved since the last report? | Accepted process, passed test, closed defect class, completed migration object.

Forecast

What do we expect now? | Date or range with confidence and assumptions.

Risk

What could change the forecast? | Dependency, defect trend, decision delay, capacity, data quality.

Decision needed

What must someone decide? | Options, recommendation, consequence of delay, decision date.

Evidence

Why should the reader trust the status? | Test result, reconciliation, throughput, defect ageing, signed decision.

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08 / MEETINGS

A meeting should earn the time it consumes.

Use synchronous time for disagreement, decisions, problem solving, coordination, and difficult human conversations. Move simple status transfer into written updates.

Decision meeting

Send context and options before the call. Start with the decision question. | Decision, owner, conditions, actions.

Working session

Bring the artefact: process, design, test evidence, data, or incident timeline. | Changed artefact, not just discussion notes.

Daily coordination

Focus on blockers, dependencies, and next handoffs. | Re-plan where needed.

1:1

Use the time for context, feedback, development, load, and concerns that do not belong in a group meeting. | Clarity and follow-up, not surveillance.

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09 / SELF

Protect judgment before protecting busyness.

A Lead becomes a bottleneck when every message feels urgent and every problem receives immediate personal attention.

Control / influence / observe

Separate what we can change now, what we can influence, and what we only need to monitor. | "What is the next action inside our control?"

WIP limit

Limit simultaneous deep problems. Finish or delegate before opening another. | "Which current commitment should stop if this becomes priority?"

Timebox analysis

Set a point when investigation must produce either evidence, escalation, or a new hypothesis. | "What will we know after 60 minutes that we do not know now?"

Decision journal

Record important assumptions and expected outcomes. | "Was the decision bad, or did an uncertain outcome go against us?"

Recovery margin

Keep some unscheduled capacity for incidents, reviews, and hard conversations. | "If the week is already at 100%, where will real problems go?"

10 / LEARNING

Fix the system without removing accountability.

Blame hides information. No accountability hides repeated behaviour. We need both a safe investigation and clear ownership for improvements.

After Action Review

What did we expect? What happened? Why was there a gap? What will we change? | Small set of owned improvements.

5 Whys with evidence

Why did this condition exist? What evidence supports the next "why"? | Contributing causes, not a convenient single culprit.

Countermeasure test

Would this action have prevented or detected the failure earlier? | Controls tied to the failure mechanism.

Reusable memory

What should the next team know without rediscovering it? | Runbook, check, design rule, monitoring signal, or decision record.

05 / PRACTICE

Speak before you read

All cases are fictional. Spend 90 seconds on the question, then respond to the challenge without giving a generic definition.

CASE 01 / RACI OWNERSHIP

The UAT handoff nobody owns

Two weeks before user acceptance testing, the business expects the SAP SD team to create realistic orders. The SD team expects the test team to provide customer and material data. Integration says its order mapping is ready, but no one has agreed who proves the end-to-end result. The project manager still reports the workstream as green.

QUESTION You are the SAP Lead. What will you do today, and who must own the result?

PUSHBACK The project manager says, "We already have a project organisation chart. Why create another matrix?"

NEW CONDITION The business process owner is absent for five days. Who can accept criteria, and when would you escalate?

CASE 02 / DACI NEGOTIATION

A pricing request meets the clean-core rule

A sales director wants a special discount calculation before the next release. The SD consultant says a custom enhancement is the fastest route. The architect warns that the change could increase upgrade and testing costs. The delivery manager has promised a date, but nobody has agreed who can approve an exception.

QUESTION How will you move this conflict to a defensible decision?

PUSHBACK The sales director asks, "Are you blocking revenue because of an architecture principle?"

NEW CONDITION The workaround is legally unacceptable. What new constraint changes your recommendation?

CASE 03 / SAP SD / MM CONFLICT

Stock exists, but the sales order cannot confirm

Customer service sees available stock in a warehouse report, yet a new sales order has no confirmed quantity. Sales blames MM for incorrect inventory. Logistics says the stock is physically present. The customer expects delivery tomorrow, and the discussion is becoming personal.

QUESTION How do you calm the situation and organise the investigation?

PUSHBACK The business user says, "I do not want a technical lesson. Can we deliver or not?"

NEW CONDITION The stock is in quality inspection. What changes in your options and stakeholder discussion?

CASE 04 / SBI / SBII FEEDBACK

The expert who silences the team

A senior consultant is technically strong and often rescues difficult defects. In three design reviews, the consultant interrupted a junior colleague before test evidence was presented. After the meeting, the junior colleague stopped raising concerns. A delivery manager suggests ignoring it because the senior person is hard to replace.

QUESTION What exactly would you say to the consultant, and what would you change in the team?

PUSHBACK The consultant responds, "I was only trying to save time. We have a deadline."

NEW CONDITION The behaviour continues after two direct feedback conversations. What is your next step?

CASE 05 / DELEGATION MOTIVATION

Everything waits for the Lead

A capable SD consultant asks the Lead to approve every configuration detail. At the same time, the Lead receives incident questions, design requests and meeting invitations throughout the day. Two decisions are late, and the consultant says they feel they are not trusted.

QUESTION How do you delegate without losing control of delivery quality?

PUSHBACK The project manager says, "If something fails, you will still be responsible."

NEW CONDITION The consultant makes a poor decision inside the agreed boundaries. How do you respond?

CASE 06 / SAP MM / FI PROBLEM SOLVING

Procurement and Finance argue over an invoice

A supplier invoice is for 100 units, while the purchasing team can see only 80 units received against the purchase order. Finance says the invoice cannot be processed as expected. Procurement says the missing 20 units are on the way and wants an immediate fix. Each team claims the other owns the problem.

QUESTION How would you separate process facts, SAP behaviour and responsibility?

PUSHBACK The procurement manager says, "Can we just change the tolerance so this invoice goes through?"

NEW CONDITION The goods were received physically, but the SAP goods receipt was not posted. Who acts first?

CASE 07 / PLANNING REPORTING

The status is green; the release is not ready

Go-live is in twelve days. The status report is green, but several high-impact defects remain open and test execution has slowed. An external interface owner has not confirmed its cutover support. The sponsor says the date cannot move because customers have been informed.

QUESTION How do you present the risk and make a decision possible?

PUSHBACK The sponsor asks, "Are you telling me to delay go-live?"

NEW CONDITION Every critical defect is closed, but no full end-to-end test has passed. Is that enough?

CASE 08 / INTEGRATION INCIDENT LEADERSHIP

An interface fails while teams trade blame

During a busy order-processing period, incoming sales orders stop appearing in S/4HANA. Sales says the middleware is down. Integration says the source system sends bad data. The business has no single view of how many orders are affected or whether resending them could create duplicates.

QUESTION What do you organise in the first 30 minutes?

PUSHBACK The business says, "Please resend everything now. We cannot lose these orders."

NEW CONDITION Only one customer is affected, but it is the largest customer. How does priority change?

CASE 09 / AI GOVERNANCE

The business wants AI to release blocked invoices

An operations manager proposes an AI assistant that will read invoice exceptions and release blocked invoices automatically. The team expects faster processing, but nobody has specified the allowed actions, error cost, audit trail or when a human must decide. A product owner wants a working demo in two weeks.

QUESTION How would you design a useful first step without giving AI uncontrolled authority?

PUSHBACK The manager says, "If a human still has to approve it, where is the value?"

NEW CONDITION The assistant works well on common cases but fails on rare high-value invoices. What changes?

CASE 10 / NEGOTIATION EXECUTIVE COMMUNICATION

A sponsor adds three countries before Friday

The project is ready to test an initial sales process for one country. At a steering meeting, a sponsor asks to include three more countries in the same release. Local taxes, pricing and shipping rules have not been analysed. The sponsor calls the change "just copying configuration" and says there is no extra budget.

QUESTION What do you say in the meeting, and what do you do after it?

PUSHBACK The sponsor replies, "A Lead should find a way, not tell me what is impossible."

NEW CONDITION The extra countries become a legal requirement. How do you replan and communicate the change?

06 / MODEL ANSWERS

Compare and repeat

These examples are not the only valid answers. They demonstrate evidence, judgement, ownership and concrete follow-up.

ANSWER 01

The UAT handoff nobody owns

I would start from the missing deliverables, not from the organisation chart. I would list test data, mapping evidence, execution, defect triage and business acceptance. In a short meeting, I would assign one accountable person and one responsible owner for each item using RACI. The business process owner must confirm the acceptance criteria, while the technical teams own their checks. I would ask each owner to confirm the date and evidence of completion. Then I would update the plan and report that the status depends on these handoffs. A RACI matrix is useful here because the problem is missing responsibility, not a technical design decision.

CHECK Notice the concrete deliverables, one A for each, business acceptance, evidence and an honest status update.

ANSWER 02

A pricing request meets the clean-core rule

I would first confirm the business result and the real deadline. Then I would ask the architect and SD team to prepare options: standard pricing configuration, a supported extension if needed, and a temporary business workaround. We would compare delivery time, risk, maintenance and the effect on billing. I would use DACI to name one driver and the person authorised to approve the choice. I would recommend the simplest option that meets the requirement without creating unnecessary long-term risk. I would document the decision, the test evidence we need and the point when we must review it again. The goal is to protect revenue and system health together.

CHECK Look for business interests, genuine alternatives, explicit authority, SAP impact and a recorded trade-off.

ANSWER 03

Stock exists, but the sales order cannot confirm

I would start with the delivery promise and give the business one clear owner for the answer. I would not assume that physical stock must be available for this sales order. We need to check the plant, storage and stock status, requirements, dates and the availability-check rules in this system. SD, inventory and possibly warehouse teams should compare the same material and document evidence together. I would separate confirmed facts from possible causes and set a short time for the investigation. Then I would explain the realistic delivery options to customer service. Only after we find the cause would I support a master-data, process or configuration change.

CHECK Do not confuse stock visibility with ATP confirmation. Separate evidence, accountable communication and technical investigation.

ANSWER 04

The expert who silences the team

I would speak with the consultant privately, not accuse them in the group. I would describe one clear situation: during the design review, the test explanation was interrupted before the evidence was shared. I would explain the impact: the team may miss defects and junior colleagues stop contributing. I would ask what the consultant intended and listen to the answer. Then I would agree on one visible change, such as hearing the full risk and evidence before challenging a proposal. In the next review, I would give all relevant people time to speak and check whether the behaviour has changed. Technical strength does not remove the responsibility to work well with others.

CHECK Specific observation, impact, intent inquiry, future behaviour and follow-up. Avoid personality labels.

ANSWER 05

Everything waits for the Lead

I would keep accountability for the workstream but change how decisions are made. First, I would agree with the consultant on the result they own, the constraints and the evidence needed. I would give them authority to decide standard configuration details inside defined boundaries. Changes that affect architecture, other processes or major business risk would still come to me with options and a recommendation. We would have short review points rather than approval for every step. This gives the consultant room to develop while keeping important controls. I would also reduce my own work in progress and make escalation conditions clear. Delegation should increase ownership, not remove support.

CHECK Distinguish accountability from personal approval of every task. Include guardrails and skill development.

ANSWER 06

Procurement and Finance argue over an invoice

I would review the purchase order history, goods receipts, invoice reference and the relevant invoice-verification settings before suggesting a change. We need to know whether goods-receipt-based invoice verification is active and why the invoice is blocked or treated differently in this process. I would ask Procurement to own the supplier and delivery facts, and Finance to own the accounting and payment controls. The SAP team would provide the system evidence and options. We should not change tolerances just to clear one case without understanding the financial risk. I would agree on the correct business action and record who will confirm the final document and account status.

CHECK Avoid assuming every quantity mismatch behaves the same in every system. Separate business action, FI control and SAP evidence.

ANSWER 07

The status is green; the release is not ready

I would not decide from a colour on the dashboard. I would show what has passed, what is still untested, the severity of open defects and the support dependency. I would run a short pre-mortem with the team: what failure could stop order entry, delivery or billing on the first day? For each material risk we need an owner, mitigation, contingency and trigger. I would prepare choices for the authorised go/no-go group, including the business consequences of proceeding or delaying. My recommendation would depend on agreed release criteria and evidence. I would communicate the uncertainty early, not wait until the night before cutover.

CHECK Give facts, release criteria, options, risk ownership and decision authority. Never promise safety without evidence.

ANSWER 08

An interface fails while teams trade blame

I would set one incident owner and a short update rhythm for the business. First, we need to understand the impact: affected order range, time window and whether orders are delayed or missing. The technical team should trace a small sample from source to middleware to SAP and find the first place where the expected state is wrong. We would check error messages, correlation references and processing status. Before replaying data, we must understand duplicate risk and the recovery method. I would separate immediate recovery from deeper root-cause work. Once the flow is restored, we would reconcile the orders and agree on monitoring and prevention.

CHECK Prioritise containment, correlation, safe replay, reconciliation and clear business communication over blame.

ANSWER 09

The business wants AI to release blocked invoices

I would begin with the exact exception types, volume and business cost. We can first test an assistant that explains the mismatch, finds relevant evidence and proposes the next action. SAP remains the system of record, and release decisions follow the approved business controls. I would use historical or synthetic cases to measure accuracy, wrong recommendations and time saved. For a first pilot, a human should review the proposed actions, especially where payment and compliance are affected. Only after reliable results and formal approval would we consider narrowly controlled automation. I would also define logging, access rights and a clear way to stop or reverse an action when possible.

CHECK Define measurable value, approval authority, audit evidence, security and failure handling; do not confuse recommendation with posting authority.

ANSWER 10

A sponsor adds three countries before Friday

I would acknowledge the business reason for the request and make the missing information visible. Adding countries may affect tax, pricing, logistics, master data, integration and testing. I would not give an estimate before a short impact review. I would offer choices: keep the original release, add one country after clear acceptance criteria, or expand scope with an agreed change in date and capacity. For each choice I would explain risk and evidence needed. I would ask the authorised sponsor to confirm the priority and record the decision. My job is to find feasible options and explain their consequences, not to accept a promise we cannot support.

CHECK Negotiate outcome rather than defend a fixed position; provide feasible options, scope impact and recorded commitment.

07 / REHEARSAL SHEET

Six checks before you finish

- What business outcome am I protecting?
- What facts are confirmed, and what must be tested?
- Who owns the work, and who approves the decision?
- What options are feasible, and what is each trade-off?
- What do I do immediately, and what requires escalation?
- What evidence will confirm a safe and useful result?

Useful B2 response starters

- I would start by clarifying the business impact and the decision owner.
- Before changing configuration, I would check the evidence.
- The trade-off here is delivery speed versus long-term risk.
- Let us separate immediate recovery from root-cause investigation.
- I would agree on the next action, the owner and the evidence of completion.

Further reading

- RACI chart - Atlassian
- DACI and Pre-mortem - Atlassian Team Playbook
- SBI / SBII - Center for Creative Leadership
- BATNA - Harvard Program on Negotiation

Full source and current methods: dkharlanau.github.io/labs/assessment/leadership-toolkit/